Build one swap-rules engine this quarter; defer WhatsApp and the custom overtime build

To: CEO · **From:** Product · **17 Oct 2026** · **Decision needed:** approve the sequence below. Engineering validates one estimate next week.

Recommendation

- **Build:** credential gate (S1), rules engine with auto-approval (S2–3), hours-cap rule with approver (S4), rollout (S5), buffer (S6).
- **Do not build:** WhatsApp approvals, a custom UrbanMart branch, a full credential suite.
- **Why:** the three requests are the same check on a shift assignment. Slow manual approval is what separates our weak accounts from our healthy ones. The two accounts we can still save by renewal (CarePoint, FreshBowl) and our largest (UrbanMart) are ₹254L, 62% of ARR.

1 The three requests share one cause: manual, slow, unchecked approval

Account	Asked for	Needs	Evidence
FreshBowl ₹84L · Jan 27 **At risk**	Swaps requested and approved on WhatsApp	A decision in minutes, with the same checks	38% approved in 24 h. Staff agree a swap on WhatsApp in 10 minutes, then wait a day; half skip the app. The manager approves "almost all", checking only training and overtime.
CarePoint ₹60L · Dec 26 **At risk**	Block expired certificates	Same: an automatic control, not a manager's Excel	Audit found two shifts covered by lapsed BLS; one more finding means a penalty. Ask and need match.
UrbanMart ₹110L · Aug 27 **Healthy**	Regional approval above 48 h	Overtime control (9% of wage bill) without more approvals	Already 36% of swaps wait over a day. A blanket approval step adds load; escalate exceptions only.

The churn sits in shift-heavy accounts, and approval speed is the symptom. The four restaurant, cafe and gym accounts hold ₹160L (39% of ARR). All are at risk or on watch, with 29–41% approved in 24 h and managers spending 5.5–7 h a week on scheduling against 2.5–4 h elsewhere. Two of the four accounts we lost (₹41L, half of ₹80L) were restaurants. In total ₹220L, 54% of ARR, is at risk or on watch and renews by March 2027 (Fig. 1).

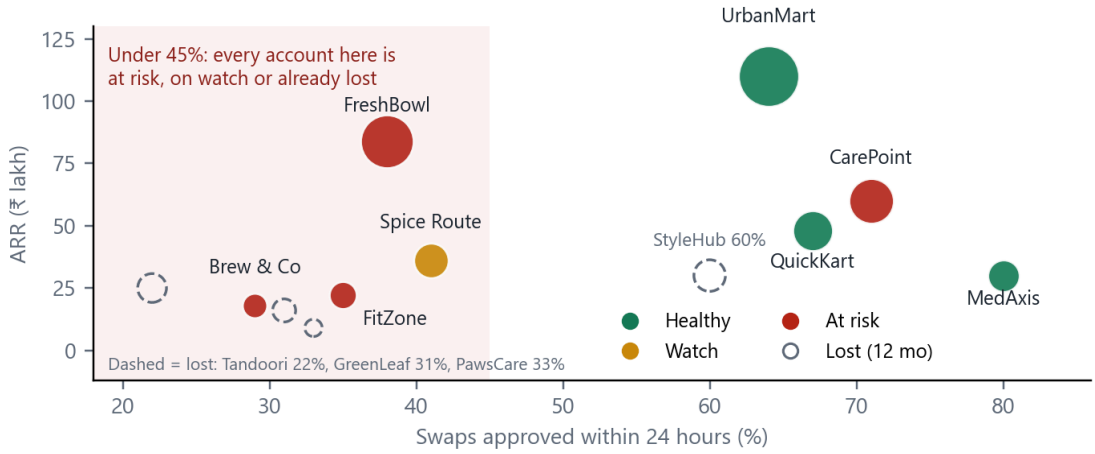


Fig. 1. Approval speed vs account status; bubble = ARR. Directional, not causal: 12 accounts, and restaurants are structurally swap-heavy.

It is not WhatsApp. Only GreenLeaf (₹16L of ₹80L lost) left for a WhatsApp competitor, and its former head of operations says managers couldn't keep up and RotaPro auto-approved trained staff. Three of four lost accounts were at 22–33% on 24-hour approvals.

Approval is a rubber stamp that costs a day, not a manager-hours problem. A typical FreshBowl location sees about 24 swaps a month: 2–4 hours of approvals against about 28 hours of scheduling. The "25–30 a night" quote is 34 times the chain average, so I treat it as an outlier. Auto-approval buys speed and safety; building the roster is the bigger manager burden, a candidate for next quarter.

2 Options considered: only the engine meets all three asks and keeps a buffer

Option	Sprints	Fixes approval delay	All 3 asks	Verdict
A. Build as asked: WhatsApp, UrbanMart custom, certificates	6	○ Same approval, new screen	●	**No: no buffer, three code paths**
B. Hard-code certificates, overtime, a simple auto-approve*	5	◐ FreshBowl only	●	**No: each new ask costs a sprint**
C. Rules engine: credential, hours, training as settings	4 + 1	● Auto-approve eligible	●	**Recommended: keeps a buffer**
D. Certificate gate only, wait for estimates	1	○	○	**No: FreshBowl, UrbanMart wait**

*Auto-approve unestimated; I assume 2 sprints. Alongside C, Customer Success calls FitZone and Brew & Co, which renew before anything ships.

3 Plan: each release lands before the renewal it protects

Sprint	Ships	For	Exit check
S1	**Credential gate.** Required credentials per role, with expiry, checked against the shift date. Blocks scheduling; swaps into an expired certificate cannot be approved. Expiry alerts. Admin-only override, logged.	CarePoint	Live early Nov. Warn-only for 14 days, then enforced. CS loads their Excel.
S2–3	**Rules engine.** Credential and training checks, auto-approval, exception queue, decision log, eligibility shown to staff.	FreshBowl pilot (5–10 stores)	≥85% decided in 24 h (38% today). Hypothesis: about 80% auto-approved.
S4	**Hours-cap rule** with a designated approver, as a setting.	UrbanMart	Live by 11 Dec.
S5–6	Rollout, hardening, manager training. S6 is buffer, then the WhatsApp decision on pilot data.	All	No valid staff wrongly blocked.

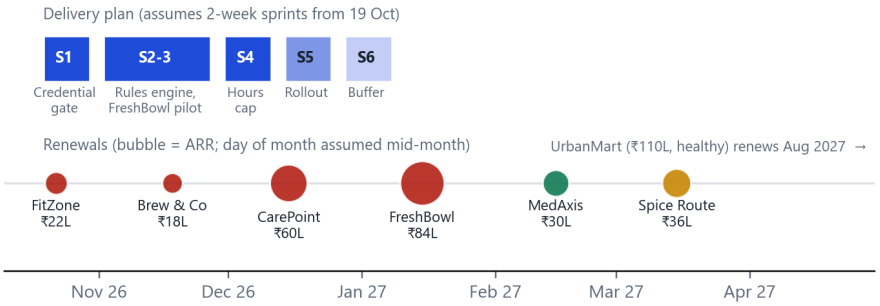


Fig. 2. Delivery plan (2-week sprints from 19 Oct) against renewals. S5 ends 25 Dec; if the quarter closes 31 Dec, the buffer is what we lose.

The engine estimate is mine, not Engineering's: about 2 sprints (range 1.5 to 3), plus about 1 for the hours rule. At 3 the plan fits with no buffer; beyond that the hours rule ships as manager escalation.

Not building

- **WhatsApp approvals (3 sprints).** Half of capacity to relocate the same approval. Message cost is small (about ₹0.5L a year for FreshBowl); the sprints are the cost. If FreshBowl makes it a renewal condition, a notification-only version on the engine comes next.
- **A custom UrbanMart build (2 sprints).** Single-customer code at about twice the cost of the same rule as a setting.
- **A credential suite** (uploads, verification) or a regional hierarchy. One "approver" designation only.

What we tell each account

CarePoint	Credential block ships first, early November, for BLS and council registration. Send your credential list and name one Admin owner. This week, Customer Success runs an expiry check against your sheet.
FreshBowl	Swaps that pass training and overtime checks are approved instantly; the rest reach the manager. Pilot from late November in stores you choose. WhatsApp is reviewed after the pilot, with real numbers.
UrbanMart	The 48-hour rule arrives as a setting, targeted 11 December once Engineering confirms. Please help define the week boundary and your approvers.
FitZone, Brew & Co	Renewals come first. Customer Success calls this week with a place in the pilot. Any commercial offer is your call.

Measures (weekly, per account): % decided in 24 h, share auto-approved, off-app swaps, blocks and overrides, overtime share of wage bill. **Risks:** bad credential data blocking valid staff (warn-only first); a wrong auto-approval (logged; unknown training goes to a person); the engine estimate.

Reply to the sales head

Deliverable 2 · 174 words

Thanks for the memo. The stakes are real: UrbanMart is 27% of ARR and RotaPro is a credible competitor.

The data points elsewhere. GreenLeaf's former head of operations told us it wasn't WhatsApp: managers couldn't keep up with approvals, and RotaPro auto-approved trained staff. Three of the four accounts we lost were at 22–33% on 24-hour approvals; our four weakest today sit at 29–41%. WhatsApp costs three of our six sprints and leaves that unchanged.

So we build one rules engine. UrbanMart's 48-hour rule becomes a setting, not a custom build, targeted for 11 December with half the effort. That is a delivery this quarter, not a no.

Certificates aren't only a clinic issue. CarePoint's ₹60L renews in December after an audit finding, and the gate is one sprint. Diagnostics and gyms likely need it too.

Two asks. Find out what UrbanMart's VP means by "look at options", since it isn't in our notes, and who their regional approvers are. And join me on the FreshBowl call: auto-approval first, WhatsApp reviewed after the pilot.

Assumptions

Deliverable 3 · every assumption made where the data pack was silent

- **Capacity and calendar.** Six sprints is the team's total, including testing. Sprints are two weeks from 19 Oct, so S5 ends 25 Dec and S6 (buffer) ends 8 Jan. Renewal dates are given as months; I plot them mid-month.
- **Engine estimate.** About 2 sprints (range 1.5 to 3); the hours-cap rule about 1 on top. Mine, to be validated by the engineering lead.
- **S1 scope.** The given 1 sprint covers the credential field and the scheduling block. Blocking swaps at approval, expiry alerts and a basic override log are assumed to fit; if not, they move into S2. Automatic swap blocking arrives with the engine.
- **Credential data.** Customer Success loads CarePoint's expiry dates from their Excel; no import screen in v1. After 14 days warn-only, a missing required credential blocks. Unknown training goes to the manager.
- **Hours rule.** Week is Monday to Sunday, scheduled hours, leave excluded. v1 covers swaps and extra shifts; roster building shows a warning. Approval at roster publish is a stretch item, so UrbanMart's literal "any shift" ask is partly staged.
- **Regional approver.** No such role exists. I assume one "approver" designation set by Admin, built in S4.
- **Auto-approval.** About 80% of FreshBowl swaps are eligible (the manager "approves almost all"). The 85% target is a hypothesis that exceptions keep today's pace.
- **Volumes.** "25–30 a night" is 34 times the chain average of 24 per location per month, so treated as an outlier. At average volume, approvals take about 2–4 h a month at 5–10 minutes each. The benefit is speed and safety, not manager hours.
- **Off-app swaps.** The line cook says half. Recorded counts therefore understate demand; I have not sized it.
- **WhatsApp cost.** Four messages per swap at ₹0.35 is about ₹4,000 a month (₹0.5L a year) for FreshBowl.
- **Causality.** Health labels and approval rates are as given. Twelve accounts show a pattern, not proof.
- **Certificates beyond clinics** (diagnostics, gyms, some restaurant roles) are an inference. Clinics and diagnostics are ₹90L, 22% of ARR on 10% of locations.
- **Churn evidence.** Sales-recorded reasons are unverified; only GreenLeaf has a first-hand exit call. "Look at options" comes from the sales memo only. No customer was contacted.
- **Churn base.** Opening ARR is ₹408L plus ₹80L lost, so about 16% gross churn, ignoring new logos.

Build note

Deliverable 4 · 177 words

The prototype is a clickable single-file web app with no backend. It shows the new experience for four roles: staff and location manager on mobile, a regional approver, and Admin on the web. Pick FreshBowl, CarePoint or UrbanMart and follow a guided walkthrough: staff see who can take a shift before asking, the rules engine decides, and the right person is told. Managers see only exceptions. Admin edits rules, previews the effect on past requests, publishes, and overrides blocks with a logged reason. A release switch shows the product as of Sprint 1, 2–3 and 4+. A handoff tab holds the decision table, data model and open questions.

AI: several tools, including ChatGPT and Claude, were used to cross-check the analysis, logic and code, alongside my own thinking and drafting. Chat links can't be shared; I'm happy to walk through the process.

A real version needs: a per-role credential model with expiry; versioned rules; weekly-hours logic (week boundary, leave, both sides of a swap); approver routing; decision and audit log; notifications; warn-only mode; feature flags and tests.

Links

Deliverables 5 and 6

Working prototype	https://hanvithsai.github.io/Shiftwell/
Source and case files	https://github.com/hanvithSai/Shiftwell
AI chat link	Not shareable. Multiple AI tools were used for cross-validation; available to walk through in the interview.